

The Promotion of Premium Cigars on Social Media

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Abstract

Introduction: The health effect of premium cigar smoking is determined by patterns of use and perceptions, which are shaped by marketing messages. The tobacco industry uses brand-owned media promotion on social media to market its product. However, premium cigar brands' promotion of their products on social media is unknown.

Aims and Methods: Forty-seven premium cigar brands were reviewed. For each brand, we identified the social media accounts and examined the content of the 10 most recent posts of each social media platform to identify the marketing themes in July 2022. We also assessed the presence of age-gating and the dates of the posts.

Results: Of the 47 brands, 65% ($n = 31$) had Facebook and Instagram, 56% ($n = 27$) had Twitter, 21% ($n = 10$) had YouTube, and 17% ($n = 8$) had "other" (e.g. LinkedIn and Pinterest) accounts. Age-gating across these platforms ranged from 0% to 49%. Marketing themes identified from 981 social media posts included product features, alcohol, holidays, events and festivals, discounts and sweepstakes, taste, family, quality, lounges and clubs, culture, innovation, masculinity, and "other" (e.g. fundraising for charity and celebrity endorsement).

Conclusions: Premium cigar brands are using brand-owned social media to promote their products using similar strategies (e.g. discounts and sweepstakes) used by other tobacco industries but also using novel themes (e.g. fundraising for charity, events and festivals) to enhance engagement. Ongoing comprehensive surveillance of premium cigars' marketing is needed on social media to inform marketing restrictions to protect public health, including priority populations such as youth.

Implications: This study is the first to identify that premium cigar brands are promoting their brands and products on brand-owned social media, using diverse themes and strategies to engage and appeal to the public. Age gating of the promotional content on social media was low. Findings suggest that marketing restrictions to reduce the appeal of premium cigars among youth is needed to reduce tobacco-related harm.

Introduction

Premium cigars are a type of cigar product, along with filtered cigars/little cigars, cigarillos, and other large cigars.^{1,2} All these cigar products are similar in that they are not cigarettes, and they are wrapped in leaf tobacco or other substance containing tobacco. They mainly differ from each other in their size. Although there is no formal definition of premium cigars, the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (National Academies) Committee on Patterns of Use and Health Effects of "premium cigars" and priority research defined them as being handmade, filled with at least 50% long-leaf filler tobacco, wrapped in whole leaf tobacco, not having filters or tips, weighing at least six pounds per 1000 units, and having no characterizing flavor other than tobacco.²

The most recent evidence on the health effects of premium cigars suggests that although smoking any tobacco is associated with an increased risk of negative health effects, including cancer and respiratory diseases, the overall health effect is determined by the pattern of use.² Current evidence suggests that individuals who smoke premium cigars tend to smoke premium cigars nondaily or occasionally and are less

likely to inhale the smoke when smoking a premium cigar, although concurrent or past cigarette smokers are more likely to inhale.² Individuals who do not inhale cigar smoke may have lower health risks than if they were to smoke more frequently and inhale. The patterns of tobacco use, including perceptions, initiation of use, and continued use are shaped by marketing messages.^{3,4} In particular, certain priority populations such as youth, young adults, and minoritized groups such as black/African Americans are often targeted by the tobacco industry, including the mass-merchandise cigar industry, with marketing themes that emphasize cultural themes that resonate with these populations.^{3,4} Thus, to determine the overall health impact of premium cigars and to reduce tobacco-related health disparities, it is important to understand how premium cigars are marketed.

Despite this crucial need, there is very limited knowledge of how premium cigars are marketed. Unlike other tobacco products, premium cigars are promoted in lifestyle magazines that are primarily focused on cigars, such as *Cigar Aficionado*, which has contributed to the increase in the use of premium cigars in the 1990s.⁵ A recent analysis of cigar lifestyle magazines (i.e. *Cigar Aficionado*, *Cigar Journal*, and

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Cigar Snob) in 2021 indicated that these magazines portrayed premium cigar use as fun, social, masculine, luxurious, and representing a successful lifestyle.² They also emphasized themes of high quality, taste, new cigar trends, innovations, celebrity endorsements, cigar lounges, and sex appeal (e.g. scantily dressed women). In addition, premium cigars are marketed on other print and digital media (e.g. paid print advertisements on other magazines not focused on premium cigars such as travel, and direct-to-consumer marketing such as e-mail ads), which feature themes of culture, music, and festivals.² However, there has not yet been an examination of premium cigars' promotional activities on social media.

Social media provides an optimal source for the tobacco industry to market tobacco because it is less regulated and it has the potential to reach many people at a low cost and fast speed.⁶ It allows strategies to engage users through options to "like" or "share" posts and it can target consumers based on their demographics and prior viewing and engagement history. Indeed, tobacco promotion is prolific on social media.^{6,7} The promotion of tobacco products on social media is problematic because social media is used by youth at high rates,⁸ and growing research indicates that exposure to tobacco promotion on social media is associated with tobacco use initiation and continued use.⁹

To counteract tobacco promotion on social media, the social media platforms have implemented guidelines that vary in scope to restrict tobacco promotion on their platforms.¹⁰ For instance, most social media platforms restrict paid advertisements such as banners that pop up on users' feeds; however, the tobacco industry can bypass these restrictions by creating their own social media accounts that are then used to promote their brands and products.^{11,12} This type of promotion is characterized as "owned media," defined as promotion through a tobacco brand's own website/social media account.¹³ To see the content of the brand's social media posts, consumers typically have to "follow" the account or click on the brand's social media account. However, the content can also be shown through users sharing the brand's post, which has the potential to reach many people. Despite the growing presence of the tobacco industry's effort to leverage social media for marketing, to the best of our knowledge, there is no information on how premium cigars promote their brand on social media. Understanding how premium cigars promote their brands and their products are important to inform effective tobacco control efforts. Although the content of these brand-owned promotions may not fall under certain marketing restrictions set forth by the social media platforms, it can be regulated by federal entities.

As part of the National Academies 2022 report, *Premium cigars: patterns of use, marketing, and health effects*, the Committee conducted an environmental scan to identify the presence of the premium cigar industry on digital media (i.e. websites and social media platforms) to fill the gap in the literature.² The Committee found that 77% of the premium cigar brands had an official brand website and 66% had a Facebook and an Instagram account, 57% had a Twitter account, and 23% had a YouTube in 2021. However, the marketing themes present on these platforms have not been examined. Thus, the goal of this study was to expand on the National Academies Committee's examination of social media by providing updated information on the presence of premium cigars on social media and identifying the marketing themes used on social media posts.

Methods

Procedures

To assess the premium cigar brands that consumers use, we examined the brands that were already identified in the National Academies report on Premium Cigars.² Please see Appendix C in the National Academies' report for more detailed information on the procedures to identify the brand names.² In brief, three cigar researchers independently coded the list of brands identified from the Population Assessment of Tobacco and Health Study and National Survey on Drug Use and Health. The brand names were coded as premium or non-premium based on the pre-specified definition of premium cigars (See Introduction for the definition) and confirmation through manual examination of the brand and vendor websites available at the time. Any disagreements on coding were discussed with an additional cigar researcher.

For each premium cigar brand, the official premium cigar website was identified via Google search, and the official brand social media accounts were identified through links provided on each of the official websites in June 2021² and confirmed again in July 2022. Each social media was visited to manually obtain the metadata (e.g. number of likes, followers/subscribers, posts) of the accounts, and we coded the marketing themes on the most recent 10 posts for each social media platform. Other studies have observed that examination of the content of 10 social media posts is sufficient to identify the promotional content of tobacco brands.^{11,14} We also assessed whether the social media platforms had age-gating. Age gating refers to requiring one to sign in to an age-verified account to access the content.

We used an iterative inductive and deductive approach to identify themes. First, we assessed whether the themes identified in the National Academies' premium cigar report on the cigar lifestyle magazines were present (e.g. health risks, enjoyable social activity, masculinity, sex appeal, taste, other substances, and quality). We also identified any new themes through discussion between two independent coders.

To establish interrater reliability, two independent coders trained in the codebook double-coded 10% ($n = 100$) of the randomly selected posts. The Gwet's AC1 values ranged from 0.92 to 0.99, indicating "almost perfect" agreement for all categories except for 0.58 for product features and 0.62 for the "other" category, which was "moderate" and considered to be an acceptable agreement.¹⁵ A third coder resolved any differences.

Data Analysis

We conducted descriptive analyses to assess the frequencies of premium cigar brands' social media accounts. For each social media account, we conducted descriptive analyses to examine the metadata, such as the number of likes (Facebook), posts (Instagram), Tweets (Twitter), and followers (for all social media), and whether they had age gating. We also obtained the frequencies of each of the marketing themes present on the 10 most recent posts of each social media platform. We presented unweighted n and % for categorical variables and median and inter-quartile range for continuous variables because of the non-normality of the data. Data analyses were conducted using STATA 17.0.¹⁶

Results

Of the 60 premium cigar brands identified in the National Academies report, we excluded eight which were sub-brands, and five which were discontinued at the time of our examination, so 47 unique brands were included in our analysis. Please see [Supplementary Material](#) for the list of brand names. Premium cigar brands used Facebook and Instagram most frequently, followed by Twitter and YouTube ([Table 1](#)). Age gating of the brand's website/social media ranged from 0% to 41.9%.

[Table 2](#) lists the frequency and description of each marketing theme identified on premium cigar brands' social media posts. The most common marketing theme was "other," which included a wide range of themes including pairing premium cigars with coffee, featuring or giving away cigar-related accessories such as ashtrays, fundraising for a charity, content that features sex appeal (e.g. eating sushi off scantily dressed women), music (mostly dance/hip hop), celebrity endorsement (e.g. a basketball player, a hip-hop artist), or features of cigar or smoking accessories such as an ashtray. The next most featured theme was alcohol (e.g. hard liquor such as bourbon, whiskey, and gin) followed by holidays (e.g. posts that acknowledged or celebrated weekdays/weekends). Of the social media posts, 66.1% were posted in 2022, 19.4% between 2020 and 2021, and 14.5% between 2009 and 2019.

Table 1. Premium Cigar Brands' Social Media Presence (N = 47)

Social media platforms	N (%) or Med (inter-quartile range)
Facebook	
Brands	31 (66.0%)
Likes	13,508.5 (26,989)
Followers	17,604 (32,067)
Age gating	11 (36.7%)
Instagram	
Brands	31 (66.0%)
Posts	670 (1209)
Followers	23,800 (56,097)
Age gating	13 (41.9%)
Twitter	
Brands	27 (57.5%)
Posts	3,997 (8234)
Followers	13,600 (14,917)
Age gating	1 (3.7%)
YouTube	
Brands	10 (21.3%)
Channel views	42,266 (901,734)
Subscribers	1,130 (5,885)
Age gating	0 (0%)*
Other (e.g. LinkedIn, Pinterest)	
Brands	8 (18.2%)

Median = median. "Age-gating" means that underage youth younger than 18 years are unable to access.

*The premium cigar brands' YouTube Channels did not appear if searched for it on YouTube with the "restricted mode" turned on, however, these Channels could be accessed with an underage account through a direct link provided on the official website.

Discussion

The goal of this study was to identify the presence of premium cigar brands' official social media accounts and the marketing themes present on these platforms. Premium cigars' social media accounts had a large following, with more than 56,000 followers and 66% of the posts were posted in the past 7 months when we conducted the search in July 2022. Our findings indicate that premium cigar brands are actively promoting their brand and product on social media, using similar themes used in marketing on print media (e.g. premium cigar lifestyle magazines, direct-to-consumer mailers).²

For instance, we observed a high number of posts that showcased a cigar product using a variety of methods such as professional images of the brand logo and cigars and reposts of the images of the brands/cigars posted by users. These images included people holding or smoking cigars or cigars placed/smoked in vacation locations such as beaches. We also observed a high frequency of alcohol marketing. The heavy presence of alcohol such as hard liquor in premium cigar marketing is also seen in premium cigar magazines.^{2,17,18} Pairing of alcohol and tobacco can also be found in other tobacco marketing (e.g. cigarillos and hookah).^{19,20} However, alcohol use among premium cigar users in the United States is higher than among non-premium cigar users (89.0% vs. 74.9%),²¹ which indicates the need to better understand how alcohol and premium cigars are co-used and how marketing contributes to co-use. The presence of alcohol in cigar marketing and the higher use rate of alcohol among premium cigar users is concerning because of the additive adverse health risks of using both substances. Co-use of tobacco and alcohol increases the risk of certain cancers, such as health and neck, esophageal, and gastrointestinal cancer.²²⁻²⁴

Featuring alcohol in premium cigar promotion is also consistent with the portrayal of premium cigar use as a social, fun, party lifestyle that involves events/festivals, and bars/clubs/lounges. It is noteworthy that premium cigar festivals are also linked with alcohol (e.g. Big Smoke Meets WhiskyFest). The marketing themes that link tobacco use to a fun, social activity have been used heavily by the tobacco industry to appeal to youth^{25,26} and are used widely by different tobacco product brands on social media.²⁶ Also as observed in cigar lifestyle magazines, we observed that some promotional content on social media appeared to target men by featuring stereotypically masculine themes such as fishing (e.g. giving away fishing gears as part of a sweepstake) and content that has sex appeal (e.g. scantily dressed women).

The marketing themes that were relatively unique to premium cigars were mentions of lifestyle magazine articles that featured premium cigars, which indicates the important role of these magazines in promoting premium cigars.^{17,18} The themes of culture and family were also observed and appear to be uniquely linked with premium cigars. Cultures featured were often Latin American cultures (e.g. Nicaragua and Cuba) and mentions of the family included how a specific premium cigar brand was a family business.

We identified a variety of strategies that have been used by other tobacco industries to leverage the interactive nature of social media, but which have not been linked with the premium cigar industry.¹¹ For instance, the premium cigars' social media posts were reposts of the customers' photos of themselves smoking cigars and required users to follow their account or tag their friends on social media to enter a

Table 2. Marketing Themes in Premium Cigar Brands' Social Media Posts (N = 981)

Themes	N (%)	Description
"Other"	319 (32.5%)	Any theme that did not fit into a specified theme listed below. Examples include co-marketing with themes of coffee, femininity, or music; fundraising for a charity; content that has sex appeal; features of accessories such as an ashtray; live streams of podcast-style interviews; and celebrity endorsement (e.g. a basketball player, a hip-hop artist).
Product feature	302 (30.8%)	A professional or "repost" of images of a new or an existing cigar, announcement of a new cigar, or breakdown of the different parts of a specific cigar. Images included people holding a cigar, smoking a cigar, or cigars placed in vacation locations such as beaches.
Alcohol	126 (12.8%)	Presence of alcohol; mostly hard liquor such as bourbon, whiskey, and gin.
Holidays	121 (12.3%)	Holidays (e.g. St. Patrick's Day, Christmas), weekly posts that mention days of the week (e.g. Happy Monday, Fuente Friday, and Whiskey Wednesday), birthdays, anniversaries, or other well-known dates (e.g. Superbowl).
Social	65 (6.6%)	People having fun with other people (e.g. laughing, embracing, playing sports, and engaging in other leisure activities.).
Events and Festivals	53 (5.4%)	Posts at or announcements/information on events (e.g. weddings), festivals (e.g. Big Smoke Meets WhiskyFest), or expos primarily centered around cigars.
Magazines	41 (4.2%)	Reviews, articles, quotes, or posts from cigar magazines/websites/publications (e.g. <i>Cigar Aficionado</i> , <i>Cigar Dojo</i> , and <i>Cigar Journal</i>), nominations of awards from cigar magazines.
Discounts and Sweepstakes	32 (3.3%)	Sales, sweepstakes, deals (e.g. inclusion of a collectible or accessory with the purchase of a cigar), mentions of affordability of cigars.
Taste	32 (3.3%)	Specific details about the taste of cigars (e.g. smooth, flavors comparing it cigars to the taste of coffee).
Family	23 (2.3%)	Mentions family (e.g. premium cigar business being a family business).
Quality	22 (2.2%)	Superior processes and material of cigars and other products. Uses terms such as "handcrafted," referring to "good," displays items in a way to show "excellence."
Lounges and Clubs	22 (2.2%)	Features cigar lounges, bars, or clubs but also non-cigar venues.
Culture	20 (2.0%)	Posts that contain aspects about the customs, arts, beliefs, institutions, or achievements of a certain nation, people, or other social groups (e.g. Cuba, Nicaragua).
Innovation	17 (1.7%)	Novel cigars such as blending tobacco in ways not done before, break with normal convention.
Masculinity	17 (1.7%)	Qualities or attributes typically regarded as male characteristics (e.g. hunting, fishing).

Marketing themes are listed in the order of frequency. Each post was coded for more than one theme, if relevant.

sweepstake to win cigars and other products. These findings add to the body of literature that shows that the tobacco industry is using interactive features on social media to increase brand loyalty and to create an overall sense of positive norm

for their brand and of cigar use through sharing others' experiences.²⁶ Concerningly, this content is available to underage youth.

We observed that age-gating on social media was low. Given that exposure to tobacco marketing on social media is associated with tobacco initiation and use among youth,⁹ preventing youth from accessing pro-tobacco content that has youth-appealing themes on social media is important. However, age gating is not a comprehensive method to restrict youth access. It is easy to bypass age-gating because one can enter a fake birthdate or sign up for a social media account using fictitious information. Indeed, we observed that age gating is insufficient to prevent youth access. For example, although YouTube's algorithm blocks underage youth's access to a premium cigar brand's channel if searched for it on YouTube's search engine, this restriction does not apply when underage youth click on the direct link of the premium cigar brand's channel provided on their website. These findings suggest that age gating of pro-tobacco content by social media platforms may be insufficient and more comprehensive federal policies are needed to restrict youth access and exposure to pro-tobacco content on social media and other digital media platforms.

The "Other" theme, which captured a diverse range of themes with low frequency, was the most frequent theme observed, which suggests that social media posts of premium cigar brands have a large range of content to appeal to a wide range of audiences. Interestingly, we observed some charity posts, such as "GivingTuesday" fundraisers for the Boys and Girls Club and Breast Cancer Awareness. These findings suggest that premium cigars are engaging in "corporate social responsibility" projects that are aimed to enhance their positive public image like other tobacco brands are doing.^{27,28} It is also noteworthy that these organizations could appeal to women. Recently, other non-premium cigar companies have used social justice issues such as Black Lives Matter in their social media marketing to appeal to the black/African American community.²⁹ Targeting tobacco marketing to priority populations by emphasizing "corporate social responsibility" is another tactic that can lead to tobacco use and create health disparities. Thus, such tactics should be prohibited.

Strengths/Limitations

The strength of this study is the examination of the promotion of premium cigars by premium cigar brands on social media, which has not been examined previously. Despite this strength, limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings of this study. We examined premium brands used by U.S. consumers so they may not be a comprehensive list of all premium cigar brands that are in the market. "Owned media" promotion may also include brands' official websites, which are geared toward multiple audiences such as customers, investors, and policymakers. Future studies should examine whether products are being sold on these websites and evaluate the presence and effectiveness of age-gating to prevent youth access to the content and purchasing of the product. Additionally, "owned media" is only one type of promotion that exists on social media and there could be other types of promotion such as "paid media" (i.e. promotion through paid online advertisements) and "earned media" (i.e. promotion through a third party, such as influencers who are paid to promote tobacco products on their social media accounts).¹³

Influencer promotion of premium cigars needs to be better understood. One study examined top cigar brands' (which included all types of cigars including premium cigars) use of influencers on Instagram and found that 29% of these brands had official Instagram accounts that used at least one influencer in the past 20 posts (8% were premium cigar brands).³⁰ These social media influencers' posts had photos taken at a brand-sponsored event, the influencer holding a cigar, wearing branded merchandise, or showing a brand logo. The use of influencers to market tobacco products is concerning because influencers integrate tobacco promotional content into their own account to make it seem organic, more socially normative, or aspirational, to enhance the appeal. Influencers can also amplify their reach by sharing the content with their own large number of followers. However, identifying social media influencers is difficult because social media influencers do not disclose their funding despite Federal Trade Commission regulations requiring them to do so.³¹ In our examination, we identified some well-known celebrities promoting premium cigars (e.g., a hip-hop artist). However, less known is whether and how social media influencers are promoting premium cigars. Future studies should examine premium cigars' use of diverse promotional strategies on social media to gain a comprehensive understanding of marketing strategies used in this space to inform marketing regulations.

Other sources of "earned media" could be third-party retailers who are marketing directly and selling premium cigars to consumers on social media.² The current study examined marketing themes used on social media but future studies should also examine whether premium cigars are being sold on social media platforms. The promotional and commerce strategies used on digital media other than social media such as online retailers and brand-owned websites also warrant attention. Furthermore, future studies should continue to monitor the changes in brands and promotional and commerce strategies used on social media and on other digital media over time as tobacco regulatory policies and digital media evolve.

Conclusions

Premium cigars have a large social media presence, and their online marketing themes emphasize that premium cigar use is part of a luxurious and successful lifestyle, which involves social events and festivals that often pair "premium" alcohol with premium cigars to create a sense of exclusiveness. These are the same marketing themes used by the premium cigar industry dating back to 30 years ago.⁵ We also observed new themes such as strategies to enhance the positive social image of premium cigar brands and to increase interactions with consumers. Concerningly, age-gating on social media was low. To reduce the overall public health harm of tobacco products, tobacco marketing in venues that are frequented by youth and young adults should be restricted, which includes social media, and counter-marketing campaigns should address premium cigar marketing content that appeals to young people.

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Declaration of Interests

The authors do not have any conflicts of interest to report.

Data Availability

The data used for this study will be shared on reasonable request to the corresponding author.

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